

**‘Government should be on your side. Not secretive or remote, not expedient or wasteful. Not acting for self interest, but committed to the national interest. On the side of children needing a better start in life. On the side of those suffering at the hands of thugs or drug dealers. On the side of patients waiting too long and businesses with ambitions. Scottish Labour is on your side and the Scottish government I lead will be too.’**



# **On your side**

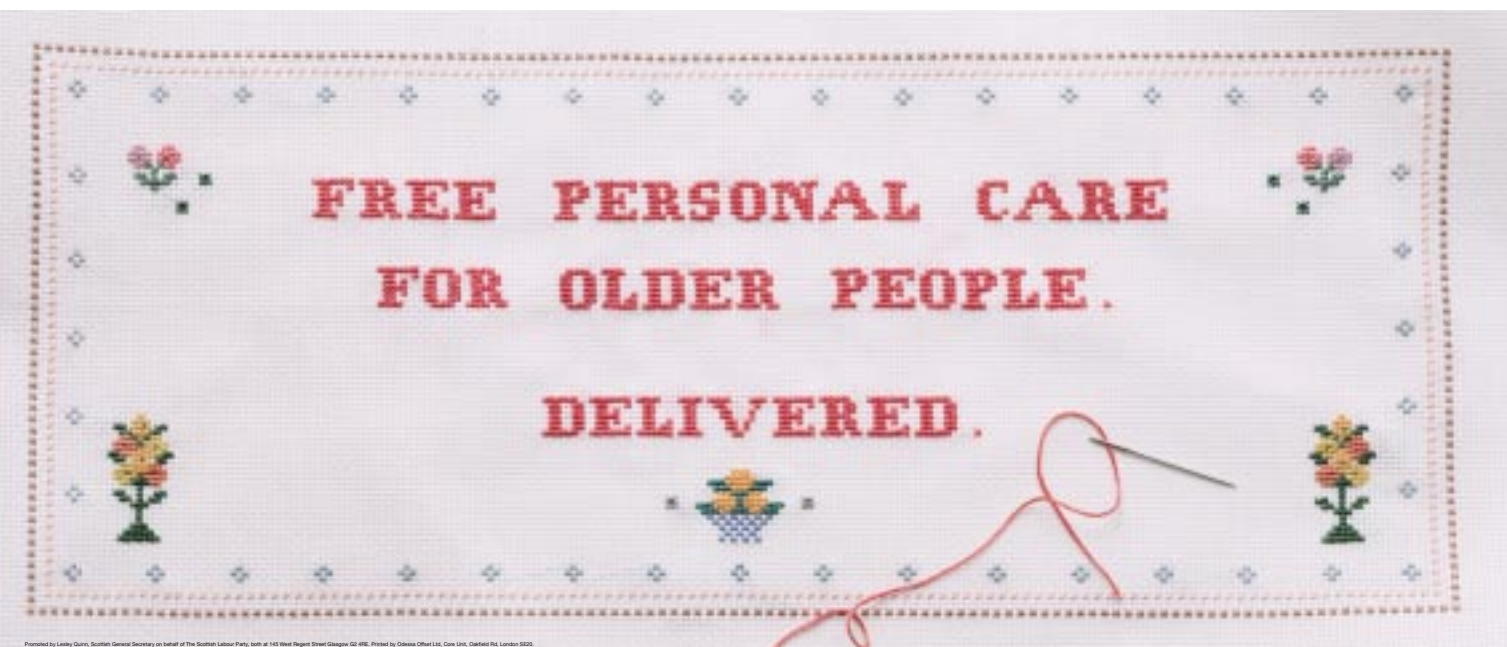
## **Scottish Labour's Manifesto 2003**



Just the beginning. **Scottish Labour**



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This manifesto contains the details of our plans for the future of Scotland.

If you would like to find out more about our policies, join the Labour Party or make a donation to Labour's election fund, please call 08705 900 200 or visit our website at [www.scottishlabour.org.uk](http://www.scottishlabour.org.uk).

## Contents

### Chapter 1

#### 6 BUILDING SCOTLAND'S ECONOMY

- 9 Investing in Scotland's People
- 10 Investing in Infrastructure
- 12 Supporting Business
- 13 Growth for All of Scotland

### Chapter 2

#### 16 BUILDING EXCELLENT PUBLIC SERVICES

- 18 Excellent Schools
- 19 The Highest Standards For All  
Choice for Pupils
- 20 Creating Opportunity
- 22 Improving Scotland's Health Service
- 23 Promoting Good Health
- 24 Patients First  
Health Professionals – The Vital Asset

### Chapter 3

#### 28 BUILDING STRONGER COMMUNITIES

- 29 Caring for Children and Young People
- 31 Safer, More Secure
- 32 Safer Communities, Safer Streets
- 34 Our Quality of Life
- 35 Tackling Poverty, Generating Opportunity
- 36 Decent Homes for All
- 37 Protecting the Environment, Delivering Environmental Justice
- 38 Celebrating Scotland's Culture

### Chapter 4

#### 40 BUILDING A CONFIDENT, DEMOCRATIC SCOTLAND

- 41 Partnership, Scrutiny and Progress
- 42 Local Government, Local Democracy
- 43 Scotland in the UK, Europe and the World

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# A Scotland we can all be proud to call home

On 1 May, Scotland will elect those who will serve for the second term of our new Scottish Parliament. I believe we need to build on the platform of economic stability and the major investment we are making in public services to create the kind of Scotland we can all be proud to call home.

Government should be on your side. Not secretive or remote, not expedient or wasteful. Not acting for self interest, but committed to the national interest. On the side of children needing a better start in life. On the side of those suffering at the hands of thugs or drug dealers. On the side of patients waiting too long and businesses with ambitions. Scottish Labour is on your side and the Scottish government I lead will be too.

I have always believed in the power of a Scottish Parliament to make a difference. I still feel angry about all those wasted years when Scotland suffered under-investment and decline, and we did not have the opportunity to make our own decisions to change life in our communities.

My vision is of a Scotland where opportunities to grow and prosper are enjoyed by all young Scots regardless of their background; where we use our partnership inside the UK, and our unique identity at home and abroad, to promote our country and all we can offer; a Scotland with strong communities where all older Scots have dignity in retirement, and families have a quality of life fitting in the 21st century.

I am impatient for the change that will move Scotland in that direction.

I became First Minister at a difficult time in the life of our young Parliament, and I have worked tirelessly to bring stability, direction and action on Scotland's priorities to the heart of government. But Scotland's hard working families want, need and deserve more. Now is not the time for complacency or to dismantle the foundations we have laid. It is time to go further, to take the radical steps forward set out in this manifesto.

I am immensely proud to be Scotland's First Minister. In this manifesto we set out Labour's vision for the Scottish Parliament and the detailed policies and ideas we seek to implement. In this election we seek a mandate to advance that vision and serve the people of Scotland.

## **Building on the start we have made**

In the first four years of our young Parliament of course there have been disappointments – no institution is perfect – and there have been real achievements too.

Better services, like nursery places for every three and four year old, free personal care for elderly Scots and free local bus travel.

New laws with tougher action on sex offenders, new rights for victims of crime and reform of land ownership.

New ways of working from a fresh approach to growing Scottish businesses to new contracts to modernise teaching in our schools.

## **Taking Scotland forward**

In the four years ahead, Scotland needs leadership committed to higher growth, excellent public



services, strong communities and building our confidence at home and abroad.

Higher growth is vital if all our other ambitions for Scotland are to be realised. We will use the opportunity provided by the strength of the UK economy with the lowest interest rates, inflation and unemployment of my adult life, to invest in the future. Skills, communications and transport infrastructure – underpinning our drive to increase business growth and enterprise – are the long-term priorities that will improve investment, research and development, exports and ultimately jobs.

To support the drive for higher growth, but also to ensure all our citizens can share in prosperity, we need excellent public services too. We will use the opportunity afforded by record levels of investment in education, health and criminal justice services to deliver real improvements in every community, large or small, urban and rural. That means reform – new ways of working, putting the patient, the pupil and the victim of crime first. National standards, local delivery and transparent systems of inspection and accountability to drive up standards.

Stable jobs, successful companies and excellent services provide the foundations for our prosperity,

but too many Scots still live in poverty, or are trapped in a poor environment, scared to leave their homes, with no-one to turn to. To rebuild those damaged communities, we need better housing but with reforms which give more responsibility to owners and tenants; support to tackle poverty but also opportunities for families to take responsibility for their own future; action to clean up our environment, but also more personal responsibility for recycling and taking care of our open spaces.

And we need to tackle crime and disorder. Tougher sentencing, new powers for the police and local councils, more police officers on the beat, prisons and punishments that reform rather than encourage youngsters to reoffend. It is time to shift the balance, not just to put victims first, but to protect ordinary decent families in their own homes and streets.

For the future, we must capitalise on the increased profile and interest in our country around the world. We can promote Scotland for work, investment, tourism, goods and products, and we can increase our influence at home and abroad. I am determined to do that. But we also need to promote a better Scotland too. My commitment to challenge racism and

sectarianism, to tackle the culture of ill health and environmental damage, and to create a nation of ambitious entrepreneurial youngsters who want more and believe they can achieve it are about the kind of Scotland we are. But they are also about the way we are perceived in other countries too. If we are to be a better place, and we are to return the welcome we receive across the globe, it is time to put the practices of the past behind us and emerge into the ambitious, modern, multi-cultural, healthy and clean country we should be.

#### **Government for the long term**

As First Minister of Scotland I guarantee to:

- Take decisions for the long-term, not for short-term advantage or headlines.
- Reform services and government so we get value for money.
- Stand up for Scotland's interests, in the UK, in the European Union and abroad.
- Be open and transparent in government and use talented people to help whenever we can.
- Use the powers of devolved Scotland in the interests of Scotland, not as a battering ram for endless conflict with the UK.

#### **The choice**

The choice Scotland faces in the election on 1 May is not a personality contest between people with the same priorities, not a potluck between parties who have the same policies, and not incidental to the future of our country. Politicians are not the same and parties do have different priorities.

It is a choice between two futures.

We can build on what we've started, inside the UK, using the powers of devolution to take our country forward or we can rip it all up and start again with the Nationalist's plans for a separate Scottish state and risk all the upheaval and uncertainty that would create at this difficult and challenging time in Scotland and elsewhere.

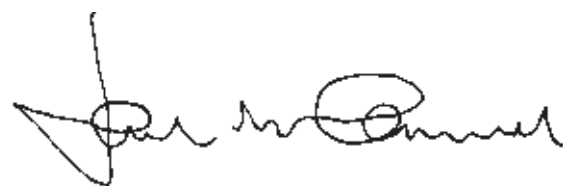
#### **Ambitions for all**

As a nation we have many talents, successes and advantages, but too often we hold ourselves back. Too quick to criticise, too hesitant to take a risk and try something new, too slow to change the bad habits which stop us being all we can be.

But as I travel around Scotland meeting people from all walks of life, and as I travel abroad to represent our nation, I am struck by what is good about us and our way of life. Young people helping in their school or local area, parents determined to see their children succeed, older Scots more mobile and involved than ever before. Talented artists and sportspeople. Businesses that create the jobs, products and services that make our country tick. World-class universities. And Scotland can be even better still.

We have the opportunity to really change Scotland for good. Ideas, change and ambition for our country must drive us on.

That is Scottish Labour's mission. A lot has been done, but there is so much more to do. Together we can build a better Scotland.



**Jack McConnell**  
**First Minister of Scotland**  
**and Leader of Labour in the**  
**Scottish Parliament**

**‘But as I travel around Scotland meeting people from all walks of life, and as I travel abroad to represent our nation, I am struck by what is good about us and our way of life. Young people helping in their school or local area, parents determined to see their children succeed, older Scots more mobile and involved than ever before. Talented artists and sportspeople. Businesses that create the jobs, products and services that make our country tick. World-class universities. And Scotland can be even better still.’**

# Building Scotland's Economy

Labour's number one priority for Scotland is a growing economy. A Scottish economy built on stability, where we use the powers of our Parliament to create the conditions for higher growth and development by investing in our people, supporting business and building the transport and communication infrastructure of our country.

There is nothing more important to Labour than moving Scotland's current long-term growth rate into the fast lane of the international community.

Growing the economy is central to everything we do because economic growth and development allows us to improve our public services, open up opportunities so all of our citizens can contribute to our shared prosperity, and strengthen our communities.

Devolution offers Scottish business the best of both worlds. The sound management of the UK economy by Labour and the independence of the Bank of England have shown us that our future need not be tied to the roller coaster, boom and bust economics of yesterday.

Inflation and interest rates are at their lowest levels for a generation and mortgage rates are now lower for every working family. In Scotland, 146,000 more people are now in work since Labour was elected in 1997 and unemployment is down by 65,000 to



its lowest level for 30 years. We now have unprecedented resources to fund the reform and improvement of our public services and an efficient taxation and regulatory framework for business.

Labour's plan for growth in Scotland works in partnership, complementing our economic policies in the UK. Our strategy, 'Smart, Successful Scotland', focuses on skills, on innovation, supporting business and global connections - a strategy that looks beyond the cyclical nature of elected politics to the medium and long term. We take Scotland's economic growth seriously and we will take decisions for the long term.

Devolution means we have the levers to create growth, and the stability of the UK economic framework gives us the platform from which to grow our economy.

In the first four years of the Scottish Parliament, we have taken the first steps. We have supported innovation in business, creating new companies and products. We have built links between our universities and business to translate the good ideas in higher education into products and processes for economic growth. We have implemented our commitment to relocate government jobs, spreading the benefit of

government spending across Scotland, frozen business rates and brought in a new rate relief scheme for small businesses.

But we can only compete by maintaining Labour's hard won economic stability and investing in skills, training and infrastructure. We must work harder to build Scotland's economic prosperity by improving our skill base so we can compete in the high tech, high earning, high productivity knowledge economy. We will work with businesses to increase their investment in research and development to more closely match our competitors in the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development.

We will continue to encourage investment from overseas through the work of Scottish Development International. But our strategy is based on a strong commitment to ideas and businesses grown in Scotland and we will continue to use the Regional Selective Assistance Programme to support growing Scottish companies.

Labour is on the side of people who want to set up their own businesses and on the side of those who want their businesses to grow. We will streamline the support and practical help government offers them, to make sure that it is accessible and meets their business needs and we will improve the planning system so that it

works faster and allows investment decisions to be made more quickly.

Labour listens. We know that our goal of increased economic growth is shared by business and trade unions alike. We have already established an annual forum with the Scottish Trades Union Congress so that we can exchange ideas and tackle the challenges that we face. And in a second term we will support the establishment of an annual Business Forum, bringing together Scotland's businesses and Scotland's politicians to develop ideas and maximise the drivers for growth.

Our six cities are the building blocks for a successful Scotland. We will work with Glasgow, Edinburgh, Dundee, Aberdeen, Inverness and Stirling and their neighbours to prepare growth strategies that maximise the unique characteristics and opportunities of each city. We will return vacant and derelict land to productive use, opening up opportunities for businesses and communities. And we will work with local authorities to establish Business Improvement Districts and Urban Regeneration Companies.

Going for growth means taking risks. We need to be prepared to support those with the courage to start up a business and end the culture that makes one failure a failure for life. In a second term, we will bring forward legislation to modernise personal bankruptcy laws to strike a better balance between supporting business risk and protecting the rights of those who lend or are owed money.

And, for a growing economy, Scotland needs to attract and retain the talents of more people. At a time when Scotland is slowly de-populating and our demographic profile is ageing, we must retain the talent we have, attract Scots back home and welcome people from different cultures, nationalities and backgrounds. And we will regenerate those communities where there are persistently high levels of unemployment.

We will build on the success of the financial services sector, particularly in Edinburgh and Glasgow, and work with the industry to improve provision for the skills and training in the areas they need most.

Scottish manufacturing remains a vital sector of our economy. A successful future for manufacturing will be in high skill and high added value products. We will continue to promote manufacturing and engineering to our young people through initiatives like 'Make It In Scotland'. We will pursue the creation of centres of excellence in industries such as aerospace and we will target emerging opportunities for Scotland such as renewable energy, where we can lead in research and production.

A sustainable environment is vital to Scotland's economic growth. To succeed we must maximise the generation and use of sustainable energy sources. As a country we are rich in sources of renewable energy. We will work in partnership with the UK government to meet our target for 40 per cent of Scottish energy production to be from renewable energy sources by 2020.

#### **But we want to do more.**

Working towards this target also opens up the opportunity to drive forward linked areas of economic growth. Scotland can be a world leader in the research, design and manufacturing technologies for renewable energy and we will work with business to develop and implement a green jobs strategy.

- **We will support the start up and growth of Scottish businesses, especially manufacturers with the potential for expansion**
- **We will work with Scottish businesses to improve investment in research and development and enhance productivity**
- **We will invest in the skills of Scotland's people and the transport and communications infrastructure of our country**
- **We will make sure that economic growth and its benefits are shared by all of Scotland's communities**
- **We will promote Scotland as a good place to live and work, with a high quality of life and attractive to fresh talent from around the world**

## **Investing in Scotland's People**

Scotland has a proud educational tradition that we should cherish and build upon. It is a Scottish strength and one that Labour believes is critical for the future.

In our first four years we have secured the highest ever levels of participation in higher and further education - abolishing tuition fees and introducing a new Graduate Endowment. We have encouraged people of all ages to update their skills and knowledge by simplifying access through Learndirect Scotland. We have opened up opportunities to skills and training for all young Scots by introducing over 20,000 proper apprenticeships, through the Modern Apprenticeship programme.

#### **But there is more for us to do.**

Building our skill base and focusing on science, research, ideas and knowledge is central to Scotland's future economic growth. That is why we are committed to increasing the higher and further education budget by 15 per cent by 2006.

We now have an enviable record of participation in higher education with 50 per cent of young Scots in higher education. Our increased investment will improve our university infrastructure, the quality of degrees and ensure that there is equity in access to our universities and we will legislate to merge the Higher and Further Education Funding Councils to create a more effective tertiary education sector.

We recognise the strategic importance of a higher education institution in the Highlands and so we will work with the University of Highlands and Islands Millennium Institute in support of their aspiration of university status.

Acquiring new skills and knowledge are also critical for those young Scots not in higher education. The skills we need will not only come from our universities and colleges. Labour will continue to provide meaningful opportunities for all young people, including a major expansion in the respected and credible apprenticeship programme to 30,000 places and we will offer support to those who need time to prepare before they can meet the entry standard.

#### **No-one must be left behind.**

We will maintain our commitment not to introduce tuition fees for our universities. We will review the eligibility criteria for student bursaries with a view to increasing the family income ceiling and we will review the maximum amount available from bursaries and loans. We will provide further support by reviewing prescription charges for young people in full time education and training. And we will introduce national bus and rail concessionary travel for young people, initially for all in full time education and training.

But improving skills and increasing knowledge cannot be just for young people. Labour is committed to building a high skilled, knowledgeable workforce of all ages - in and out of the workplace. We will introduce an improved version of the Individual Learning Account and offer Business Learning Accounts to help small businesses provide training opportunities for their employees. And we will encourage distance learning using new technology to offer opportunity to people in rural communities and help everyone adapt to the challenges of the new economy.

We are determined that everyone in Scotland will have the opportunity of employment. We have the highest employment levels for a generation but there are still parts of our country where unemployment is too high. Our UK based employment programmes such as the New Deal have helped over 100,000 young people gain new skills and experience, nearly 37,000 of whom have already moved into new jobs. We will support



these UK programmes with additional resources to provide childcare support in areas of high unemployment in order to help those in work, training or education make the most of the opportunities Labour has created.

To maximise our opportunities for growth, we need to build a culture of confidence and aspiration. We will start with our young people by making sure that every pupil has the opportunity to learn the skills of entrepreneurship at school. We need to offer our young people enterprise role models and increase their awareness of ideas from other countries and cultures.

This is about more than business start-up. For some this will be the first step they take to starting their own business, but we need every young Scot to be equipped with the skills and confidence needed to make their way in the world.

We will set up a Lifelong Learning Forum to involve learners, learning providers and other partners in developing and delivering lifelong learning. We will pursue developments in linked areas such as trade union learning initiatives and education for sustainable development.

- **We will increase the Apprenticeship programme to 30,000**
- **We will introduce national bus and rail concessionary travel for young people**
- **We will provide additional financial support and services for students to make sure no-one is left behind**
- **We will legislate to streamline funding in higher and further education**
- **We will not introduce tuition fees in Scotland's universities**
- **We will introduce Business Learning Accounts and re-introduce Individual Learning Accounts**
- **We will aim to close the gap in unemployment rates between the worst 10 per cent of areas and the Scottish average by 2006**
- **We will set up a Lifelong Learning Forum to develop life long learning**

## Investing in Infrastructure

One of the biggest challenges facing us as a country is making the right connections. If we are to grow the Scottish economy we need a transport and technology infrastructure fit for the 21st century.

We will work with the private sector to ensure that 70 per cent of Scots have access to broadband and where the market is not delivering we will review our own intervention to make sure we reach this target. Scotland needs to be quick – and smart – if we are to stay at the forefront of modern communications.

And we must put in place an integrated transport system that gets goods to market quickly and efficiently, and gets people to work safely and on time.

This does not mean we should rely on any single mode of transport. It is essential that Scotland has transport choices. That is why we're actively promoting bus quality contracts to improve the services available and to improve time-tabling and bus safety. And at the same time we will review the tolls on the Skye Bridge with a view to greater consistency in bridge tolling across Scotland.

We must connect the whole country. The survival of many remote and rural communities depends on good transport infrastructure, and air and ferry services must be affordable. We will continue to support and invest in these lifeline links.

We will make a fundamental shift to improve Scotland's planning and delivery of all transport services and infrastructure so that local authority boundaries do not hinder major projects and stifle growth. We will set up a single strategic transport authority for Scotland and strong regional transport delivery partnerships throughout the country.

We will extend the air routes to Scottish airports using our air route development fund. And we will continue our major investment programme in rail infrastructure in order to help strengthen the Scottish economy. Our priority projects are:

- **rail links to Glasgow and Edinburgh Airports - delivered by 2010 and providing better links for business visitors and tourists coming to Scotland**
- **opening a new east to west route by rebuilding the Airdrie to Bathgate railway**
- **re-opening the Alloa to Stirling service and construction of the Larkhall to Milngavie line**
- **implementation of a tram network and other public transport improvements in Edinburgh**
- **the redevelopment of Waverley Station in Edinburgh**

We will agree the new Scottish Rail franchise and improve on the current level of service. We have already placed an order for 28 new trains, the largest in Scotland's history. This investment will help eliminate overcrowding, increase safety and improve journey times. We will give full consideration to further improvements such as the Borders Rail Line and the Glasgow Cross Rail project when plans are developed.

Across Scotland we are investing in strategic road improvements. These improvements benefit business and commerce and reduce congestion and safety risks for local people. We will maintain the strategic road network and complete the central Scotland motorway network and the Aberdeen Western Peripheral road.

Labour believes that objective criteria should be used to determine priorities and we will conduct a second strategic roads review early in the new Parliament to agree the next steps.

We will continue to support improvements to the local road network through the resources we give to local government, coupled with the new spending freedoms we are implementing.

To free up our roads for those who really need them, we will increase the volume of freight taken off our roads, using grant aid schemes that shift heavy freight onto rail and boat. And we will consider local congestion charging schemes if public transport is improved first and only where public support has been demonstrated.



- **We will invest in the long-term improvement of Scotland's transport and communications infrastructure**
- **We will publish a White Paper in the first term of the Parliament to reform strategic transport delivery and establish a single strategic transport authority, with strong regional delivery partnerships**
- **We will promote quality contracts for bus services and maintain lifeline air and ferry services**
- **We will complete our priority transport projects on the strategic road network, airport links and rail transport improvements and take action to reduce the volume of freight on our roads**
- **We will conduct a second strategic roads review early in the next Parliament**
- **We will invest £3 billion over the next 10 years on improving Scotland's transport links.**

## Supporting Business

Scotland has a history of enterprise and innovation. For centuries our country has been rich in people with the imagination and the drive to make breakthroughs in science, engineering, medicine and technology. And we have them still.

In laboratories and research centres across Scotland we have people working on new ideas, new ways to tackle and solve old problems - in medicine, engineering, bio science and much more. But we need to offer them the opportunity to turn those ideas into products for use and export.

For too many years, Scotland allowed her ideas and talents to slip away to other countries where the final step would be taken - the step to turn our inventions into wealth.

Labour in Scotland is determined to end that. We have set up three Intermediary Technology Institutes to commission research and turn it into new businesses. We are committed to this approach for the long term. We will continue to support the translation of ideas into marketable

products through our unique Proof of Concept fund and new Research and Development support to encourage business to invest in developing products for the future.

Tourism is the largest employer in Scotland, and in 2001 the total expenditure by tourists in Scotland was £4.2 billion. This major sector offers employment to people all over Scotland and draws in every size of enterprise, from our hotels and tourist sites with an international reputation, to the bed and breakfast seasonal guest house, offering informal and friendly hospitality. We will continue to improve tourism marketing and infrastructure and increase the involvement of tourism businesses in developing the sector.

This sector has a great deal to offer our economy and room for significant growth. Labour has already provided practical support and now we will build on our cities' many attractions and the natural resources of our countryside to turn Scotland into a year round destination.

Every one of Scotland's guests should receive a quality welcome and a quality service, so we will work with the tourism sector to introduce a national tourism registration scheme to guarantee quality service and facilities across Scotland.

We will back up our use of Regional Selective Assistance to help small and growing Scottish companies with a review of the current arrangements for business grant and support schemes to cut out unnecessary duplication and provide business with the quality of support they need. And we will extend the one stop support for business throughout Scotland with the Business Gateway.

Every part of our economy needs to encourage innovation and enterprise. We will pilot a series of public sector employment contracts in our rural communities to give individuals the time and support to develop their business ideas.

And to help those with the business idea which needs small scale investment to test it out, we will set up a new Business Start Up Fund, offering support grants with minimum bureaucracy and maximum flexibility.

We are committed to the regeneration of areas that have been affected by economic restructuring and to using our investment to transform the run down parts of our towns and cities. So we will make sure that the national planning framework supports area regeneration.

- **We will improve business grant and support schemes, removing duplication and improving quality**
- **We will introduce a new Business Start Up Fund**
- **We will support the productive link between research and product development through the Intermediary Technology Institutes**
- **We will freeze business rates for 2003 / 4 and limit increases to no more than inflation for the following 2 years**
- **We will maintain our new small business rate relief break**
- **We will introduce a national tourism registration scheme**

## Growth for all of Scotland

Labour supports and works for success. But we know that there are regional disparities across Scotland and still too many communities stifled by deprivation and lack of opportunity.

### **Our strategy for economic growth is a strategy for all of Scotland.**

We are committed to ensuring our cities, towns and rural areas develop and thrive and we will work with our partners in local government and in the UK government to target our spending and our energy to close the opportunity gap.

We have made a start to help our rural communities build a sustainable future, but more needs to be done.

Farming, fishing and forestry, and the processing businesses that they supply are important parts of Scotland's economy, especially in the more remote parts of the country.

We will take steps to support the development of environmentally sustainable and competitive farming, fishing and forestry across Scotland.

We want to develop a prosperous farming industry that meets the needs of its customers, remains a

major part of the rural economy and plays a leading role in the protection and enhancement of our environment.

We will support Scotland's food and drinks industry to build on its reputation for high quality and its strong export record.

We support the principles of reform of the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP) in order to help farmers generate more income from the market and encourage environmental protection. We will continue to participate fully in the European debates on the future of agriculture and fisheries to ensure a sustainable and equitable future for these industries and secure reforms in Scotland's interest.

In areas which have been reliant on the fishing industry there are now many fragile communities. Labour has long supported reform of the Common Fisheries Policy and we have achieved a number of our policy objectives. Inshore limits for the 12 miles closest to shore will be retained until 2012 and we are delivering short-term aid to areas where fishing has reduced.

We understand the importance of the fishing industry to many rural communities and we are committed to supporting a sustainable fishing industry and to assisting communities as they deal with the changes that will come. We welcome the Prime Minister's decision to commission an urgent report on a sustainable future for the fishing industry, and will work actively to take this forward for the benefit of Scottish fishing.

To aid the sustainable diversification of these communities and meet public health demands, we will support the development and marketing of the commercial salmon market and the emerging markets of shellfish and new marine fin-fish.

We are committed to better fisheries management and a move to sustainable local control of the fishing resource. We will set in place an urgent review of the management of all fisheries within the twelve mile coastal zone. This review will build on a commitment to more local control, recognising the forward-looking work which has already been done in Shetland, which led to the Shetland Shellfish Regulating Order. We will discuss with the local community the potential to pilot a local fisheries management approach in Shetland.

Our fishing industry's future also critically involves fish processing. We will improve the promotion of Scottish fish products overseas and work to increase the range of work undertaken in Scotland, so that the fish we catch reaches the table more fully produced in Scotland.

Aquaculture plays an important role in securing diversity in the rural economy and we will support the industry to build on its success and secure sustainable growth.

And as more timber becomes available from Scottish forests, we will promote diversification in the use of forests and assist the development of new opportunities for the use of timber.

In our first four years we made a commitment to job dispersal, re-locating government jobs so that all of Scotland could benefit from the economic and social impact of government. We have come through on that commitment and have already relocated jobs to Glasgow, Aberdeen, Dundee and the Scottish Borders. In a second term we will ensure that the Highlands, south and west of Scotland benefit from this approach, spreading

the benefit of Scotland's devolved government to all of Scotland including small unit re-location to support more fragile rural communities.

- **We will support reform of the CAP to secure improvements for Scotland**
- **We will support the development of local fisheries management**
- **We will support the development of our fish processing and our food and drinks industries**
- **We will continue our commitment to government job dispersal to benefit all of Scotland**
- **We will provide practical support to innovation and enterprise in our rural communities**



**‘Higher growth is vital if all our other ambitions for Scotland are to be realised. We will use the opportunity provided by the strength of the UK economy with the lowest interest rates, inflation and unemployment of my adult life, to invest in the future. Skills, communications and transport infrastructure – underpinning our drive to increase business growth and enterprise – are the long-term priorities that will improve investment, research and development, exports and ultimately jobs.’**

# BUILDING EXCELLENT PUBLIC SERVICES

First class, responsive and efficient public services are critical to Scotland's economic growth and the health of our nation. These are the services that make a difference to our lives, that bind us together as a community.

For our public services to work as we need them to, they must focus on the needs of those who use them. The patient must be at the centre of the NHS, the pupil at the heart of the school.

In the first four years of the Scottish Parliament Labour has built strong foundations on which to build excellent public services.

With the benefit of Labour's sound management of the UK economy, we have made historic levels of investment in health and education. In the next 4 years we are committed to a further increase of 30 per cent in health spending and to taking our investment on education to over £4 billion. We have set national standards for quality and introduced inspection to maintain those standards and we have begun to take action to tackle poor performance where it exists.

We have taken the first steps to devolve decision making to those at the front line, and we have introduced stability through three-year funding arrangements for local authorities and health boards.

These have been important first steps but we must not stand still. The investment we have made and the additional investment we will commit in the next four years, must be matched by reform if we are to see the excellent public services our people need.

Our responsibility is to get the best value from every public pound we spend. For over 18 years our public service infrastructure was under-funded and run down. We have invested through Public Private Partnerships in a way that brought results in new and refurbished infrastructure. Quality rebuilding that minimised the risk to public money and delivered projects on time and on budget. Labour will continue to support PPP and other innovative models. And we have worked with the unions to agree a protocol which ends the two-tier workforce and protects workers who are transferred to new employers. In the next term, we will continue to actively implement that agreement and maintain our dialogue with the trade unions.

## **We have made a start. But there is much more for us to do.**

In a second term, we will build public services which meet the needs of a confident, modern Scotland by investing in people and in new technology. We will invest in new and modernised buildings and effective use of technology to improve the quality of service.

We want to ensure that everyone in Scotland can access the services they need with the minimum of fuss and the maximum of speed. We will build on the local pilot projects to create a national

citizen's entitlement card for all public services. One card replacing many cards and one card giving access to many services.

And we will invest in the people who work in our public services. Our investment will be matched by reform to improve quality and put services first, through improved structures and by developing a culture which empowers front line staff.

Attacks on emergency service workers - nurses, doctors, paramedics, fire-fighters - are unacceptable and those who carry them out must be dealt with effectively. Our public sector workers deserve the highest level of protection and in the next Parliament, we will legislate to introduce a specific criminal offence against those who assault, obstruct or hinder emergency workers and those assisting them as they carry out their jobs.

We recognise that not all public services work well all of the time. We will challenge them to continuously improve with independent inspection of performance and provide support where it is needed, to help all our public services reach the standard of the best. Sometimes, in exceptional circumstances, ministers may need to intervene to make sure that the very best service is delivered and continuous poor performance is dealt with. Labour ministers will take that responsibility seriously.



Our emergency services are vital to Scotland. Across the country, we now work to different patterns than even a generation ago, and homes have sprung up in areas where there were none before, or declined where previously we had a thriving community. Our fire service works hard to save lives and prevent loss. So here too we need to review provision to meet the changing location and demands of our population. For our emergency services, we want to extend the local decision making that we are committed to for all public services and to match investment with reform.

So in the next Parliament we will introduce a Fire Services Bill, building on our earlier review of the new demands and challenges the service has to meet, to modernise the service, increase local decision making to meet local needs, and protect the public. We will guarantee improved consultation with the workforce and the community before significant changes.

Scotland's courts have a long history and many valuable traditions. But the 21st century places new demands and high expectations on them which we know they are ready to meet. We will continue our reform of the criminal justice service

in Scotland. We will legislate to improve the operation and effectiveness of our High Courts and we will reform arrangements to free up police officers and others to do their jobs.

- **We will invest in our public services and reform them where needed to drive up standards and tackle poor performance**
- **We will introduce a national citizens' entitlement card, building on local pilot schemes to improve access to public services**
- **We will introduce legislation to:**
  - **protect emergency service workers from assault**
  - **reform our court system**
  - **reform our fire service and improve public safety**

## Excellent Schools

Our country is rich with people who, given the opportunity, can fully realise their talents, increase their skills and knowledge and so make a positive difference to their own lives and the lives of others. The key to making this happen is education.

It is education which opens the door to opportunity, but the opportunity of learning must not be hindered by the barriers of income or background.

We believe that the comprehensive system has improved education opportunity for all our children. But the comprehensive system does not mean a one size fits all system. Comprehensive education should deliver opportunity that meets the needs and abilities of every pupil. We will improve the comprehensive system with increased pupil choice and better information and access for parents so that they can help their child learn. Our commitment to high standards is one we take seriously so we will strengthen the role of inspection and tackle consistent under-performance to make sure that no school fails our children.

We strongly believe in the educational value of our denominational schools. We are not interested in narrowing down choice or spurning real educational achievement. Our education service offers different choices and schools across Scotland can learn from each other.

The right start comes with our commitment to maintain free nursery places for every 3 and 4 year old in Scotland, helping every child get off to the best possible start in their primary school.

But if all young Scots are to realise their potential regardless of their background or postcode, then we need every school to be an excellent school. Excellent schools, working to the highest standards and offering every pupil maximum choice and the best of opportunities.

## The Highest Standards for All

Our goal is for every single school in Scotland to be an excellent school. An excellent school is one where pupils are energetic and enthusiastic about learning, classrooms are clean and bright and staff are professional and quick to solve problems.

An excellent school has an atmosphere of mutual respect where both teachers and pupils can thrive and an excellent school is led purposefully and well by its head teacher.

For a head teacher to lead, he or she must be free to make decisions that matter to the daily life of the school and its future. Each school has different strengths and faces different challenges, so we must have flexibility in our education service to allow each school to develop and build high standards where improvement is needed. In rural areas, where there is an additional dimension, we seek to ensure that the particular needs of the community are considered before reform.

In our first four years, we have worked hard to devolve responsibility and decision making to our head teachers. In the next four years we will do more so that they have responsibility for 90 per cent of the school budget through devolved school management. We will introduce greater flexibility for schools and education authorities through local agreements for excellence.

New Community Schools are at the centre of our commitment to an education service that allows each child to develop his or her potential. In the first four years of the Parliament we tried out the approach of providing fully integrated support for

learning in the single school setting, bringing together education, health and family support. It works. In our second term we will make sure that by 2007 every school in Scotland has adopted the new community school approach.

The education of every Scottish child matters to Labour – that is why we will build the best education service, where talent and confidence can flourish.

Excellence is not dependent on school population, post-code or area. But some of our schools need to do more to reach the standards our children need and we demand. Under-performance is unacceptable and we will work with the School Inspectorate and staff to turn these schools around. We will strengthen the role of inspection, giving clearer and more frequent reports to parents.

We will not allow consistent under-performance in any school. The Inspectorate will focus their attention and support on those schools that need it most. And where necessary we will legislate to allow Ministers to intervene if they have to and enable excellent schools to provide the strong leadership that weak schools need.

Schools which are less than excellent fail our children and Labour will not allow any child to miss out on the opportunity to release their full potential.

- **We will modernise comprehensive education to secure the highest standards for every child**
- **We will tackle under-performance through inspection, support and direct intervention where necessary**
- **We will introduce the integrated community school model to all schools by 2007**
- **We will enhance the head teacher's role by devolving 90% of the decision making on the school budget**

## Choice for Pupils

Only motivated pupils will fulfil their potential in the classroom and elsewhere. We must make sure that pupils can choose and excel in subjects that inspire them, and that straightforward assessment procedures enhance, not reduce, a child's desire to learn.

To increase pupil choice, we will reform the school curriculum. We will create a well balanced core curriculum, widen choice to include vocational training and reduce the current overload for 5 to 14 year olds. Every pupil must learn the most basic skills so we will improve standards of literacy and numeracy and we will make sure that our teachers have the right skills to meet this challenge.

We will simplify and reduce the amount of assessment, so increasing the time spent on learning. We will guarantee that every pupil has the opportunity to learn a modern European language from primary school. And to encourage creativity, we will give every pupil the opportunity of one year's free music tuition by the time they reach primary 6.

We will continue to invest in Gaelic-medium education, including the provision of more teacher training places.

Pupils need to be ready for the world beyond the classroom, so we will maintain our commitment to developing citizenship and practical involvement in their community, throughout their school life.

Labour believes that it is government's job to make sure that everyone gets the chance to realise their ambitions and unlock their abilities. We will introduce financial support for all 16 to 19 year olds from low-income families to allow them to continue their education.

- **We will reform the curriculum to increase choice**
- **We will simplify and reduce assessment**
- **We will improve standards in literacy and numeracy**
- **We will encourage creativity with 12 months free music tuition by Primary 6**
- **We will guarantee the opportunity to learn a modern European language in primary school and maintain citizenship and community involvement throughout the school years**
- **We will introduce financial support for all 16 to 19 year olds from low income families, to allow them to continue their education**

## Creating Opportunity

Our schools must help every child grow in confidence and have ambition. We need to encourage young people to try out new ideas, to learn new skills, to inquire and search out information.

Building close links between schools, colleges and business helps young people prepare for the world of work and opens up possibilities and experiences that they may not otherwise encounter.

Equipping children to deal with change – such as the move from primary to secondary or from secondary to further education or work - prepares them for the world beyond the classroom.

In our first four years we opened up the opportunity for early learning and development by reducing class sizes in the first three years of primary school. But we all recognise that the real gains of primary education can be lost in the transition to secondary school.

The challenges of entering adolescence while also changing schools can make the new learning on offer difficult to grasp. We believe that there are real educational and social benefits to be gained from paying particular attention to this important period.

That is why within six months of the election we will publish our timetable to reduce class sizes to a maximum of 20 in S1 and S2 for Maths and English, as a first step.

And we will use the flexibility gained from our ground breaking teachers' agreement to make sure that specialist staff from both primary and secondary education can provide practical support to pupils as they make the often difficult transition to secondary education.

Teachers are the vital link between a child and the excitement of learning. We have increased teacher numbers by 1,100 since 1997 and introduced over 7,000 classroom assistants to our schools. In a second term, we will provide the investment to put another 2,500 teachers in Scotland's schools and involve classroom assistants in secondaries.

Violence and bullying in our schools is not acceptable. We will introduce measures to improve discipline and take strong action to tackle bullying and aggressive behaviour. Every school will have an anti-bullying policy which will be developed with parents and pupils.

We will ensure that difficult and disruptive pupils are removed from the classroom and that pupil support is provided in every school to address their challenging behaviour.

The fabric of our schools matters. We have already delivered the biggest school building programme in Scotland's history, with 100 Scottish schools built or refurbished in our first term. In a second term, we will go further. We will invest £1.9 billion across Scotland to improve a further 200 schools by 2006, rising to 300 by 2009. And we will make sure that our schools and their facilities are a resource that the whole community can enjoy.

Pupils who are healthy are pupils who are ready to learn. We will make sure that all schools work with their local health board to promote healthier lifestyles. We will continue our support for breakfast clubs and introduce nutritional standards for school meals. And building on the initiative of Labour local authorities, we will make free fruit available across Scotland for all pupils in Primary 1 and 2.

There are some young people who require specialist provision, and we are determined to give them the best possible education. We will continue to include pupils in mainstream schools where this is in their best interest, but we also recognise that some young people will require specialist provision, including access to specialist schools. What's important is what is best for each child.

In a second term we will bring forward legislation to reform education provision for children with special needs. We will end the current bureaucratic hurdles children and their parents or carers face, provide an integrated approach from education, health and social work services to support their learning and provide a mediation and tribunal service to give parents and carers a greater say in the education and support provision for their child.

Schools can achieve little in isolation. The link between home and school is vital and goes beyond report cards and parent's evenings. Many parents



and carers want to be involved in helping their child but are unsure about how to do that. We will improve the quality of information that parents receive so they know what is happening at each stage of their child's education and how they can help. And we will continue to prioritise improved opportunities for looked after children.

Schools matter outside teaching hours too. We will ensure that all schools have access to a home-link worker, summer academies, out of school support and after school clubs.

- **We will reduce class sizes to a maximum of 20 in S1 and S2 for Maths and English, as a first step**
- **We will increase the number and range of specialist teachers working with primary pupils**
- **We will rebuild or refurbish 200 schools by 2006, rising to 300 by 2009**
- **We will tackle violence, bullying and disruption in our schools**
- **We will legislate to improve the specialist provision for young people who need it, increase the involvement of their parents or**

**carers and introduce flexibility to make sure their education takes place in a setting and with the support that best meets their needs**

- **We will work to improve the health of our children, with free fruit in primary 1 and 2, improved nutritional standards for school meals and continued support for breakfast clubs**
- **We will work to strengthen the link between parents and schools**

## Improving Scotland's Health Service

Fifty-five years ago Labour created the NHS around three founding principles: healthcare available for everyone who wanted to use it; high quality provision and availability on the basis of need, not the ability to pay.

Today we are applying these guiding principles to the 21st century and a changed society. A society where patients rightly expect to come first, with the high quality of care that needs committed and professional staff in the service.

No service suffered more under eighteen years of Tory rule than our National Health Service. Turning the tide on almost two decades of under-investment and neglect has been one of the biggest challenges Labour has faced in our first four years. But investment to improve the health service is our long term commitment.

In our first four years, we have begun to make real achievements in our programme of action to re-build the health service.

We have introduced free long-term personal and nursing care for the elderly. We have increased the number of qualified nurses by 1,700 and invested in recruitment and retention initiatives to attract qualified nurses back to work and improve access to NHS dentists.

We have delivered the largest ever hospital building programme and upgraded GP surgeries, accident and emergency facilities and local health centres. We bought the HCI hospital in Clydebank for the NHS in Scotland and used its facilities to reduce waiting times and we have invested to provide a four-fold increase in the number of single visit centres providing speedy consultation, tests, results, diagnosis and treatment.

We prioritised our action to tackle Scotland's killer diseases of cancer, stroke and heart disease, securing a steady drop in coronary heart disease and implementing a well resourced cancer strategy which is making real inroads in our fight against the disease.

And to monitor and drive up standards of care we set up the independent watch dog, NHS Quality Improvement Scotland.

Step by step we are investing in the wages, career structures, training and conditions of the 136,000 people who work in our National Health Service.

Advances over the years in clinical practice, alongside our record levels of investment, changing patterns of care and increased day surgery means that we need fewer hospital beds than in the past and more local health facilities in our communities. But having the right care for patients where they need it is what matters most and so we will keep the total number of beds available under review.

Our investment in health must be targeted where it is needed, and we must search out best value for each public pound spent. We will abolish NHS Trusts and require Health Boards to implement local health plans that devolve decision making and local budget control to those at the front line.

We will set up Community Health Partnerships with a statutory basis and clear responsibilities and accountability for the delivery of local health care to drive forward our commitment to improved health care. We will consult on introducing a directly elected element to all NHS Boards.

Our health professionals work to deliver the highest standards but there are times when under-performance appears and continues unchecked. We will work with health staff and health boards to tackle poor performance through national standards, inspection and support. And where these measures don't deliver the quality patients need, we will take additional powers to intervene directly to correct areas of service, which are failing those who need them most.

It is Labour's commitment to investment matched by reform that will keep the NHS true to its founding principles within the modern setting.

- **We will reform our health service, abolishing NHS Trusts and establishing Community Health Partnerships**
- **We will legislate to increase the powers of Ministers to ensure that there is direct intervention to correct persistent or serious under-performance**

## Promoting Good Health

The NHS faces unparalleled challenges. Advances in medical research and treatment mean disease and ill health can be tackled on a scale unimaginable when the NHS was born over 50 years ago. These advances keep more of us alive, and for longer - creating new demands on health care provision.

Too many of us have to acknowledge that we have failed to take responsibility for our own health. Despite medical advance and our National Health Service, we still have the worst health record in Europe. Too many of us fall prey to cancer, heart disease and stroke. Too many of our young people lead worryingly unhealthy lifestyles.

Labour is committed to improving Scotland's national health and we have backed that commitment with significant resources - investing in the future health of our young people and the generations to come, with 100,000 children under 5 receiving free toothbrushes and toothpaste and sports co-ordinators in 80% of our secondary schools, promoting out-of-school sport and exercise. We have set up the national healthy eating hotline and won the support of food champions and supermarkets to promoting healthy eating.

We know that inequalities of wealth lead to inequalities of health. This social injustice must be tackled, so we will reward local health care systems which bring innovation to tackling the health inequalities in their area.

We will support a new Glasgow Centre for Population Health. This research and development centre will make international links and concentrate on the discovery of new practical knowledge on improving health. It will work directly with the National Health Service and the city council to tackle the health challenges that face the city.

To promote good health we will consult clinicians on a programme of targeted health checks. This will help people get the information they need to take positive choices about their own health.

In a second term, we will increase the number of full time salaried NHS dentists in areas where there are gaps in access to dental services and work with Health Visitors to ensure young children are registered with NHS dentists.

Although 80 per cent of prescriptions are dispensed without cost, the current system is confusing and outdated. We will review the current exemption categories for prescription charges to introduce greater flexibility and we will act to protect our community pharmacies which provide a vital service to many people across the country.

We will introduce hearing tests for all new born babies, and we will ensure resources are available to provide digital hearing aids and support for all those for whom this is the best option.

Labour delivered the world's first National Health Service in Scotland and the UK. We are committed to making it the best.



- **We will consult on a programme of targeted health checks available on the NHS**
- **We will review current prescription exemption categories to introduce greater flexibility and equity**
- **We will introduce hearing tests for all new born babies and invest to support the provision of digital hearing aids**
- **We will tackle inequalities in health and support the new Glasgow Centre for Population Health**

## Patients First

Scottish taxpayers and patients in our health service will rightly expect to see real change and real improvement. We need to meet their expectations. Putting patients first is our goal and to do that we need to streamline management, cut out bureaucracy and support frontline health staff.

On waiting times, we recognise that what matters most is that those in pain or distress are treated within a reasonable time. Step by step, we will continue the work we have started and bring down the longest waits for the key surgical procedures. We will give heart patients and inpatients the guarantee that they will get the operation they need, paid for by the NHS - whether from the health service or the private sector, in Scotland or elsewhere in the UK, or Europe. For many the delay comes as they wait for the first outpatient appointment. We have taken steps to tackle that. We will work with clinicians and staff to improve the appointment system and how treatment is delivered. We will bring forward the target for all first outpatient consultation to a maximum of 26 weeks by 2005.

We need to deliver all services as near to where people live as is clinically appropriate. And we need to deliver services quickly because the right diagnosis, treatment and care delivered quickly and well, improves lives and very often, saves lives. We need a health service which across the country takes the patient from diagnosis to treatment faster and more effectively. A system that makes best use of technology to move the information faster and move the patient around less.

Improving our health service is about more than medical care - whether we find that in the GP

surgery or the hospital. It is also about improving the standards of social care, bringing services to where people are - so they can remain in their own homes or near to their families.

We will invest £30 million each year for the next three years to provide 1,000 community places for people leaving hospital. And we will maintain our commitment to free personal and nursing care for the elderly. Reducing the number of people in hospital beds and caring for them in the community is the right thing to do. Not just lengthening life - but improving the quality of life.

We have laid the foundations of the health service we need for the 21st century.

**But there is much more we can do to put patients first.**

- **We will ensure that anyone contacting their GP surgery has an appointment with the GP, nurse or member of the local health care team within 48 hours**
- **We will guarantee treatment for inpatients within 9 months from the end of 2003, going down to 6 months by 2005**
- **We will guarantee of treatment for all heart patients within 18 weeks of diagnosis, from 2004**
- **We will deliver a maximum wait of 26 weeks for all outpatients by 2005**
- **We will rigorously monitor hospital action plans to improve cleaning standards so that they meet the inspection by NHS Quality Improvement Scotland in 2004.**

## Health Professionals – The Vital Asset

Our national health service has the patient at its heart. But we know that without its hard-working, dedicated staff, our NHS would be worthless.

Our nurses, doctors and allied health professionals have a range of skills, abilities and experience that we need to harness to the full to deliver the best possible care for patients. Over the years, advances in training and learning now allow nurses to undertake treatment that previously only doctors could do. Going down this road provides more fulfilling work and better career

prospects for nurses, and also allows doctors and consultants to practice their specialist skills more often and more effectively for patients.

Our commitment to devolving power and decision making to front line public sector staff is seen clearly in the approach we are actively taking to modernise our health service and put the patient at its heart. Finding new ways to meet high clinical standards and reduce waiting times, speeding up the process of diagnosis, treatment and after care, building modern and accessible local health care - all of this is being lead by our health professionals. They are tackling the problems and finding the solutions. Giving them the opportunity to lead and take the decisions is at the centre of the approach we have outlined in the Health White Paper we published earlier this year.

But taking these opportunities, and using all the skills and experience they have means that all our health staff need to challenge outdated practices and professional boundaries that get in the way of effective patient care. The work we have embarked on with our partners in the UK government, to guarantee a minimum wage of £5.18 an hour for NHS staff and to produce an Agenda for Change and revise the Consultants' and GP contracts is a critical step in realising the changes we seek, and professional staff want to deliver.

Working with all health professionals we will increase the support they receive, and in turn we will expect them to break down outdated and unnecessary professional barriers to deliver the services patients need, when they need them and where they need them.

Our hospitals operate 24 hours a day, 7 days a week, every week of the year. We need to be able to cover staff absence and continue to provide high quality care. And we need to be able to do that across Scotland, using well-qualified and trained staff who want to work for the National Health Service. Many of our trained nurses want the flexibility offered by this kind of work. We will build on the good practice developed in parts of Scotland to set up a NHS Scottish Nursing Bank, to provide nurses to the health service, as an alternative to the use of private agencies.

We are building a health service where everyone working in it is valued for the job they do and rewarded for the skill and effort they bring to



patient care. We are investing in the wages, training and career opportunities of all our NHS staff and with them, we are reforming the way our health service works to deliver high quality care.

- **We will complete our programme to recruit and train 11,000 nurses and midwives for the NHS by 2005, raising our original target by 1,500, with further sustained increases thereafter**
- **We will treble the number of nurse consultants**
- **We will continue our guarantee of one year's employment for all newly qualified nurses and midwives**
- **We will increase the number of consultants by 600**
- **We will develop health professions such as radiography and the allied health professions such as physiotherapy and occupational therapy, to reduce waiting times and deliver responsive and comprehensive care**
- **We will develop an entitlement to continuous professional development for all staff and require all Health Boards to increase flexible hours working**
- **We will set up an NHS Scottish Nursing Bank**

to provide nurses to the NHS to cover absence of permanent staff, as an alternative to the use of private agencies

- We will devolve real decision making and control over resources to front line staff by abolishing NHS Trusts and require health boards to implement local health plans
- We will double our investment in IT and develop integrated care records that are jointly managed by the patient and NHS staff
- We will increase pay for nurses by 10 per cent over 3 years, in addition to the pay improvements offered through Agenda for Change



**‘ My vision is of a Scotland where opportunities to grow and prosper are enjoyed by all young Scots regardless of their background; where we use our partnership inside the UK, and our unique identity at home and abroad, to promote our country and all we can offer; a Scotland with strong communities where all older Scots have dignity in retirement, and families have a quality of life fitting in the 21st century.’**

# BUILDING STRONGER COMMUNITIES

Scotland's communities and neighbourhoods are the nation's building blocks. If we are to grow our economy, have the best public services and release the potential of all our people, then we must build safe, strong, sustainable communities where children can flourish, families prosper and the elderly live in comfort and dignity, free from fear.

A modern country needs to harness the energies and talents of all its people. We cannot afford any of our citizens, young or old, to be excluded from our future prosperity and we cannot afford any of our communities or neighbourhoods to sink into misery and decay.

Labour wants everyone to live in a community they are proud to call their home, whether they live in rural Scotland or one of our many towns or cities. We have achieved much in four years but there are still too many communities damaged by anti-social behaviour, crime and environmental degradation.

There are still too many families living in poor housing and too many Scots trapped in poverty, their ambitions frustrated and their aspirations low. There are still too many children who are the victims of neglect or abuse.

Labour will act to give all Scots the right to a decent life and a safe community. And we will also act to balance the right to a decent and safe community, with the responsibility to keep it that way.

We want to build a Scotland where people work together to support each other, protect the vulnerable, cherish the environment and build a sustainable future.

## Caring for Children and Young People

There can be no excuse for the neglect or abuse of our children. The measure of the society we are building will be the quality of the protection it offers our children.

We have made a start in our first four years. We have reviewed child protection and children's services across Scotland, but we must now build on that. We will make sure that every agency gives

priority in their work to child protection and that vulnerable families receive the support they need through the Sure Start programme.

Support for families and carers is vital if we are to give children the best possible start in life. We will improve the procedures and the services and support for adoptive and foster parents.

We will reform children's services, cutting bureaucracy and simplifying funding. We will set up tough new inspection standards for child protection and introduce a Children's Charter to assist the most vulnerable.

We will act to establish the new Children's Commissioner before the end of 2003.

We must also provide our children with the opportunity to learn and grow, with safe places to play and leisure facilities that will excite and stretch them.

We must value our young people and give them the space and the opportunity to become confident, ambitious young adults. Education is not something that just happens in school or college. Informal learning in the community, youth club or voluntary organisation is a vital part of young people's growing experience.

In the first four years we set up a national youth agency, Youthlink Scotland and supported the Scottish Youth Parliament as an important forum for all young Scots. We have consulted young people directly on a range of issues and worked closely with Dialogue Youth and Young Scot.

But there is more for us to do. Scotland's young people have ideas, energy and voices that we need to listen to.

In our second term we will develop a national youth work strategy and continue to support the Scottish Youth Parliament as it develops its role of representing the views of Scotland's young people.

We will develop our support for 'Big Brothers and Sisters' and other mentoring schemes to support young people. Matching adult mentors with young people has been shown to provide positive role models for the young and help them grow healthily and well into adulthood, avoiding drugs, alcohol and truancy, and so avoiding the trap of poverty.

Social work plays a crucial role in Scotland's communities and neighbourhoods. Its core role

of child protection, caring for the elderly and supporting vulnerable families is vital if all Scots are to flourish. But increasingly social workers work alongside teachers and health professionals to help provide the highest quality community care and the right conditions in which children can learn and grow.

We have helped underline the valuable role of the profession by setting up the Scottish Social Services Council, the Care Commission and by setting the framework for residential and day care services. We have worked with local authorities to support the graduate recruitment scheme and the trainee programme to promote social work as a valuable career and have taken steps to improve workforce planning to put recruitment to the profession on a sounder footing for future years.

In the next four years, we will reform social work training to meet the new demands placed on the profession and we will introduce additional workforce planning arrangements to meet future demand for social care staff.

Voluntary work is the glue that holds many urban and rural communities together and improves the quality of life for so many people. We are proud of the voluntary work so many of our neighbours undertake and we believe that their commitment and support for others should be recognised. And we will introduce a national recognition scheme to support youth volunteering, giving young people credit they deserve, and can build on.

- **We will reform children's services and introduce a Children's Charter to protect the most vulnerable**
- **We will establish the Children's Commissioner by the end of 2003**
- **We will review and reform social work training to equip the profession for the critical role it has**
- **We will develop a national youth work strategy**
- **We will develop our support for young people's mentoring programmes**
- **We will introduce a national recognition scheme to support voluntary work by young people**

## Safer, More Secure

Crime hurts. It hurts decent, hard-working people and eats away at the social and economic fabric of our communities. We are on the side of ordinary decent people and against those who make their neighbours' lives a misery. We want people to be safe from crime - and free from the fear of crime.

In four short years, Labour has cut recorded crime in Scotland, delivered record levels of police and the highest crime clear-up rates in Scotland since the Second World War. We have introduced new legal powers to act against anti-social neighbours and Youth Courts and fast-track hearings to tackle youth crime. We have provided greater community protection through a strengthened Sex Offenders Register and over 2,000 CCTV cameras to prevent crime and increase community safety. We have extended electronic monitoring and restriction of liberty orders on offenders and introduced new powers to arrest those breaching non-harassment orders - giving more protection to victims of stalking and harassment. We have taken real steps to bring the victim to the heart of the criminal justice system by guaranteeing information and support to victims from our courts and prison service.

But too many communities and too many lives in Scotland remain blighted by crime. Our commitments to education and opportunity will work on the root causes of the problem. But as a priority, we must deal swiftly and effectively with those who commit crime - and put the needs and rights of victims at the heart of our criminal justice service.

We know the long-term damage that drug dealers cause in our communities. They grow rich from the misery and devastation they sell to our young people and their evil trade tears families and communities apart.

Labour has taken tough measures against the dealers. We set up the Scottish Drug Enforcement Agency (SDEA) to target police action on dealers and take drugs off the streets. We introduced new powers to seize the assets of drug dealers and set up new drug courts to deal swiftly with drug offenders, introducing drug treatment and testing orders to link treatment with sentence.

**But there is more to do.**

- **We will expand the Scottish Drug Enforcement Agency**
- **We will work with Home Office on tough action against those who deal drugs near our schools and youth facilities**
- **We will take powers to enable police and local authorities to close down commercial premises - rented, owner occupied or otherwise - where Class A drugs are being sold and used.**
- **We will prevent these premises being re-occupied by new dealers, by introducing legal means for the property to be closed and sealed for a fixed period.**
- **We will extend drug treatment and testing orders and the drug court system to Sheriff Courts where it is needed**

Children and families are important to Labour. That is why we want to end the violence that too many women still face in their own home. We have continued to act against domestic violence and have introduced tougher penalties for the possession and distribution of child pornography, a support programme to protect and help child witnesses and Scottish wide protection through the national list of adults unsuitable to work with children.

Knife crime in Scotland disables and damages too many lives. In a second term, we will review current legislation on knife crime in our determination to reduce the casual violence on our streets.

In the second term we will keep up the pressure on criminals and increase the support we give to local communities and to victims of crime. We will consult on the use of bail and remand to increase its effectiveness in protecting our communities.

We will significantly increase the number of police officers on operational duty in every Scottish Force. We will increase overall numbers as resources allow and we will invest in the support staff and technology to put professional officers on the job and on the beat.

Our radical reforms of the youth and criminal justice systems will stop the waste of valuable police time and allow police men and women to do the job they signed up to do.

We are committed to a package of action to attack crime, protect victims and support local communities.



- **We will increase the number of police officers on operational duty in every Scottish Police Force, year on year**
- **We will review parole regulations to end the current system of automatic release for short sentence prisoners at half sentence**
- **We will establish a Sentencing Commission to determine the action needed to secure consistency, effectiveness and appropriateness in sentencing across Scotland**
- **We will expand the witness service to cover the High Courts and improve protection for child witnesses**
- **We will set up a single agency – the Correctional Service for Scotland - staffed by professionals and covering prison and community based sentences to maximise the impact of punishment, rehabilitation and protection offered by our justice system**
- **We will continue community protection measures of electronic tagging and restriction of liberty orders**
- **We will review legislation on knife crime and consult on the effectiveness of our current bail and remand provision**
- **We will strengthen support for victims with increased privacy protection and specialisation in our prosecution service to deal with victims of violent and sexual offences**
- **We will review legal aid eligibility to improve coverage of domestic abuse and mediation services**
- **We will increase support for CCTV use**
- **We will introduce legislation to make kerb-crawling a criminal offence**

We will consult on our plans for a Sentencing Commission within twelve months of the election and the first priority for the Commission will be to consider and devise tougher penalties for drug dealers.

For those who commit crime there must be effective and swift punishment but this must also be matched by the chance for them to change, so they live law abiding lives alongside the vast majority of our citizens. We will cut the red tape, the duplication and the queues for drug rehabilitation and community support to make sure that individuals and families can get the help they need to end drug addiction, no matter where they live.

Crime must not pay. For too long people have been sickened by the knowledge that criminals profit from the misery they cause. In the next four years we will maximise the benefit to communities from the new Civil Recovery Unit we have set up to seize the assets from the criminal, ending their ability to profit from others' pain.

## Safer Communities, Safer Streets

It is not just the crime that makes headlines that can damage our communities. Petty, but constant acts of theft, intimidation, vandalism and graffiti grind people down and destroy neighbourhoods.

Far too many youngsters, and more than a few adults, put their selfish and ignorant behaviour before respect for others. There is a difference between right and wrong. There is a difference between civilised behaviour and unruly, yobbish contempt and all Scots must recognise that.

We have to be tough, to deliver speedy punishments that fit the crime and protect the overwhelming majority of Scots who respect their neighbours and their community.

Youth crime is a particular challenge. Thirty years of the Children's Hearing Service has seen many positive developments. We have led the world in developing a system that puts the child at its centre, involves local people in deciding what is the right thing to do and focuses on the care and welfare of young people.

The public need to have confidence that the system meets their needs as well. We recognise the values of the Hearing System but we know that nothing is perfect. Some young people outgrow the system, we need to do more to hold parents to account for their responsibilities and we need to find more effective ways of dealing with young people who continue to re-offend. We need to strike the right balance between the needs of the victim and community, and those of the young offender.

We will review and modernise the Children's Hearing System and deliver our commitment to increase the number of secure accommodation places to 125 in Scotland.

For too long the quality of local life has been spoiled by anti-social behaviour such as graffiti, vandalism and littering. Noisy or aggressive neighbours can turn a street into a living hell, and no-one wants a drug dealer as their neighbour.

We will establish alternatives to custody such as supervised working in the community to remove litter and graffiti.

Labour is committed to ensuring our neighbourhoods are safe and attractive. We have already made a start by introducing probationary tenancies through the Housing (Scotland) Act 2001. Neighbourhood Wardens can play an important role in the daily improvement of local communities. The pilot schemes have shown how, working with local police and council staff, the neighbourhood warden can deal quickly and directly with the concerns of local residents and improve the quality of local life. In a second term we will extend the neighbourhood warden scheme across Scotland.

But there is more to do. Government doesn't create safe communities on its own. We all share that responsibility and our rights must be matched by responsibilities that we have to meet.

We will introduce a Quality of Life guarantee to secure clean streets and safer communities. Our Quality of Life guarantee will set out minimum standards for the removal of graffiti and litter, address problems like fireworks and give communities a guaranteed right of consultation on decisions affecting them.

**Early in the second term of Parliament, Labour will bring forward an Anti-Social Behaviour Bill to:**

- **extend Anti-Social Behaviour Orders to under 16s**
- **introduce Parental Orders to make parents accept responsibility for their children**
- **expand Youth Courts and fast-track Children's Hearings across Scotland**
- **introduce electronic curfews for under 16s who persistently offend**
- **introduce Community Reparation Programmes to make the offender repair the community they have harmed.**
- **Strengthen local authorities' powers to tackle fly tipping and double the level of fines.**
- **Increase the penalties against those who litter our streets and extend local authorities' litter**



**intervention powers to tackle graffiti and fly-posting.**

- **Ban the sale of spray paint to under 18s**
- **Give local authorities new powers to close premises that are a repeated noise nuisance and tackle the problem of night noise in domestic dwellings**
- **And we will consult with Scotland's Police Forces on the introduction of a national system of police warnings for young offenders**

We will work with the Home Office to introduce new protections for the public against people with airguns and imitation guns who are in public places for no good reason, raise the age restriction on the possession of airguns from 14 to 17 and ban the import, sale and manufacture of particular types of easily converted air weapons.

We will extend the protection and support to witnesses of anti-social behaviour so that more offenders can be successfully prosecuted. And we will consult with sheriffs and others to determine if more powers are required in housing

possession cases, so that the impact of anti-social behaviour can be taken into account.

We will introduce 'acceptable behaviour contracts' for anti-social individuals and families and encourage better standards of behaviour by piloting 'good neighbour' declarations that set out the responsibilities of landlords, other agencies and tenants.

We will support local authorities in setting up proactive anti-social behaviour units to work with the police and neighbourhood wardens.

## Our Quality of Life

Scotland is a good place to live, but Labour wants to make it better. We want all Scots to be proud to call their community home.

But many communities, damaged by poverty, environmental injustice or crime, do not feel like home.

We want a Scotland where everyone can enjoy a decent quality of life, with homes they can be proud of and neighbourhoods they can enjoy.

In our first four years we have begun to make real headway in reversing the damage suffered by our communities through years of under-investment and neglect. We invested to deliver 137,000 warmer and more energy efficient homes, made a significant reduction in the number of people living in fuel poverty, reduced the number of people sleeping rough and increased the rights of homeless people and provided access to temporary accommodation.

We provided the opportunity for council house tenants to take community ownership of their homes, secure historic levels of investment and increase their rights and introduced a Scottish Standard which builds in crime prevention measures for all social rented housing.

These steps have been reinforced by action to improve the fabric and quality of our communities and the local environment:

### Our package of action includes:

- **A comprehensive waste plan for Scotland, backed by record levels of resources**
- **Recycling targets set for municipal and business waste**
- **£95million to councils to tackle vandalism and graffiti**
- **A new Community Warden scheme to support the police**
- **New Road safety schemes to cut the number of children killed in road traffic accidents**

Decent, warm, affordable homes and a clean, sustainable environment are essential to improving Scotland's quality of life. We will build on the start we have made with practical action in the next four years.

- **We will provide for recycling in every community by 2006 and introduce doorstep collection for every household by 2010**
- **We will work with local authorities to deal with the nuisance of abandoned vehicles**
- **We will increase protection for communities affected by flooding through investment in flood alleviation measures and flood defences**
- **We will work with the UK government and**

- **credit unions to investigate the feasibility of community insurance schemes, initially for areas at risk of flooding**
- **We will introduce a Private Housing Bill to implement our 1999 commitment to make the process of buying and selling homes easier with a single seller survey and the provision of rent to mortgage schemes**

At the moment, many communities feel they have no control over the decisions that are made around them. We will improve the planning system to strengthen the involvement of communities, speed up decisions and reflect local views more effectively.

Our rural communities have many similar needs to those in our towns and cities, but they also have challenges which are particular to them.

To improve the quality of rural life we want to encourage and develop thriving and sustainable crofting communities. We will legislate to simplify and extend the existing crofting legislation, and extend the role and powers of the Crofters Commission. We will also allow the creation of new crofts, modernise conditions of tenure to enable a wider range of uses for croft land and enable owner occupiers to let their croft lands without creating a crofting tenancy. We will extend new rights to unmarried partners of crofters, redefine the crofter's family for purposes of succession and assignation and act to minimise the impact of absent and uncooperative landlords.

Labour is proud to have introduced the right or communities to buy the land where they live and work. This will bring direct benefit to rural communities. In a second term we will see through the important measures in the Land Reform (Scotland) Act and take further steps to extend the benefits of community ownership to urban Scotland.

Across Scotland it is public transport that connects our communities. Efficient, safe and affordable public transport improves the quality of all our lives and lets us live where we want and work where we like. It allows us to use our local leisure facilities as well as enjoy Scotland's national ones. And it helps us keep in touch with our family and friends.

To improve the travel choices available to older people and the disabled we are extending the

free off-peak bus scheme, transforming it into a single national scheme, to allow users to travel from Dundee to Dumfries, or Stranraer to Stirling, using one ticket.

Travel safety is important to our quality of life – for pedestrians as well. We want to reduce the number of serious and fatal road accidents involving children by 50 per cent against the 1994-8 averages so we will work with local authorities on the co-ordinated introduction of 20 mph all day speed zones around all of Scotland's schools.

- **We will extend free off-peak bus travel for the elderly and disabled to cover journeys across all of Scotland by 2007**
- **We will introduce 20 mph speed zones around Scotland's schools**
- **We will extend community ownership to urban Scotland and improve crofting legislation**

## Tackling Poverty, Generating Opportunity

Poverty affects the quality of people's lives. It stifles ambition, destroys hope and damages individual lives as well as our country's future prospects. Working in partnership with the UK government we have already made real progress in tackling poverty in Scotland.

The minimum wage benefits 120,000 people in Scotland, two thirds of them women, and with Child Benefit increased to record levels - now £16.05 for the first child and £10.75 for subsequent children, we have provided additional support to 600,000 families. The Working Families Tax Credit has helped over 127,000 working families in Scotland. The Minimum Income Guarantee has helped 180,000 of the poorest pensioner households and we have delivered the free TV licences for over 75s and the Winter Fuel Payment, worth £200 a year to 984,000 pensioners in Scotland.

As a result of Labour's action over the past four years, the absolute levels of poverty have fallen by a third for children and have been halved for pensioners. That means that there are now 90,000 fewer children living in absolute poverty than in 1999 and 100,000 fewer pensioners.



But Scotland still has too many people living in relative poverty. The gap between those with the most and those with the least diminishes our country. We are determined to close that opportunity gap.

We need to grow the economy, build the best public services and improve the quality of life for all if we are to end child poverty for good. But as well as jobs, excellent education, good health and decent homes, we can tackle poverty by providing first class support services.

We will implement the Debt Advice Act we brought in during our first four years and extend the network of money advice workers to provide practical support and relief to those burdened by multiple debt.

We will work with the Department of Trade and Industry to introduce measures to tackle harassment by loan sharks, introduce fairer credit schemes and provide greater protection from extortionate interest rates.

We will support credit union development to ensure alternatives to mainstream banking are available and to develop community based insurance schemes.

We will take measures to support the social economy. We will establish a new Scottish Co-operative Development Agency to promote and provide advice alongside the work of Scottish Enterprise.

- **We will reduce the number of households living in fuel poverty by 30% by 2006**
- **We will extend our central heating programme, initially by directing resources to the over 80s who have outdated systems - improving another 4000 homes by 2006**
- **We will work with the Department of Trade and Industry to tackle harassment by loan sharks and introduce fairer credit schemes and new protection from extortionate interest rates**
- **We will support an extension of the money advice service to help those burdened by multiple debt**
- **We will set up a new Scottish Co-operative Development Agency to support the social economy**

## Decent Homes for All

Labour's vision for Scotland's housing is to ensure that everyone has the chance of a decent home, regardless of whether they own or rent their house.

Decent homes mean stability, security and a platform from which to achieve a person's full potential. That is why we will work to reach a 'decent homes standard' for all Scots.

We are committed to making the process of buying and selling a house easier by introducing the single seller survey, so that potential purchasers can use the survey provided by the house seller and don't have to use up their hard earned cash paying for surveys on homes they don't then buy.

To help maintain housing standards, we will roll out a common factoring scheme in private sector housing with communal areas, including homes purchased under the Right to Buy legislation.

We will increase the supply and quality of Scotland's housing stock by approving 18,000 new and improved homes for social rent and low-cost home ownership by 2006.

We will build on our success of transferring stock to community ownership, so unlocking significant investment, by developing a range of housing choices and investment opportunities to modernise social housing across Scotland.

And we will support local authorities to prepare and implement proposals for transferring 70,000 houses by 2006 to community ownership, subject to the wishes of tenants.

- **We will work to introduce a decent homes standard for Scotland**
- **We will roll out a common factoring scheme in private sector housing**
- **We will increase the supply and quality of Scotland's social housing stock by 18,000 by 2006**
- **We will develop a range of housing choices and investment opportunities to modernise social and public housing across Scotland**

## Protecting the Environment, Delivering Environmental Justice

During the first four years of the Scottish Parliament, government has worked to protect our natural heritage, improve water supplies and improve access to the countryside. But there is still much more to do.

We know that damage to our environment hits the poor hardest. Traffic fumes, pollution, and poor quality housing all affect the most vulnerable in our society: the old, the very young and the poor. As part of our commitment to environmental justice we will ensure that car fumes are reduced by supporting the use of emission reducing equipment.

Our environment is rightly recognised as being of international importance. We all have a duty to ensure that we pass it on to future generations, intact and unharmed. We will legislate to improve the system of nature conservation in Scotland to protect our wildlife, birds and natural habitats. We will also maintain our protection for the rare bird species found in Scotland through our moor land management schemes.

Water is a key natural resource, essential to communities and industry alike. We will not privatise Scottish Water and we will support it with the resources necessary to invest in our public water and sewerage services so that they meet health standards.

Scotland produces too much waste, recycles too little and puts too much waste into ugly landfill sites which scar our communities. We will implement a comprehensive plan for waste and establish recycling targets for municipal and business waste to reduce the level of landfill disposal. We will provide for recycling for every community in Scotland by 2006 and doorstep collection for every household by 2010.

Scotland has the potential to be a world-leader in renewable energy generation and use, providing clean, safe sources of power for communities and industry. Scotland can also become a centre for excellence in advancing renewable energy technologies and scientific development. We will work with the UK government to ensure that 40



per cent of Scotland's energy production comes from renewable energy sources by 2020.

The way in which Scotland produces the food we eat can have a profound impact on our communities. The quality of Scotland's food should be dependable, its sources should be sustainable and it should contribute to the health of the nation.

We will improve food safety 'from the farm to the plate' through improved farm standards, rigorous monitoring of food quality control regimes and more extensive restaurant and food premises inspection. We will implement an Organic Action Plan to increase the proportion of organic food available in Scotland. We will maintain the precautionary principle for the planting of GM crops. And we will encourage more sustainable agricultural development on the 13,500 farm businesses in Scotland's remote hills.

Scotland has many beautiful and natural resources. Not least of these is our shoreline and coastal waters. We have already created two national parks and in the next four years we will work with

our local authorities to create a national coastline park. We will lead a national effort to bring our beaches up to European standards of cleanliness, protect our coastline and promote education and tourist opportunities using the beauty and heritage our land gives us.

Our quality of life depends on the quality of our environment. Labour is committed to improving both.

- **We will legislate to protect the system of nature conservation in Scotland**
- **We will develop plans for a national coastline park**
- **We will take action to strengthen prosecution for environmental crime**
- **We will provide recycling for every community in Scotland by 2006 and doorstep collection for every household by 2010**
- **We will work to ensure that 40 per cent of Scotland's energy production comes from renewable energy sources by 2020**
- **We will implement an Organic Action Plan and maintain the precautionary principle for the planting of GM crops**

## Celebrating Scotland's Culture

Scotland's culture, from the languages we speak to the arts we perform and applaud, the sports we play and the riches we find in our libraries and museums, makes Scotland unique.

Our cultural and sporting activity enriches our lives and our communities in many ways. Labour believes that promoting the best of Scotland's culture, arts and sport will improve the quality of life for everyone.

Our vision of a vibrant, modern society means that our cultural life must be for the many, not the few. It must be inclusive and accessible, embracing a diverse range of expression across our communities, involving film, visual and performing arts, our galleries, libraries and museums.

We will consult with a view to re-organising existing agencies and establishing a new single cultural agency for Scotland. We will improve opportunity and access through music tuition support for schools and additional support to overcome the practical difficulties of access such as transport. We will devolve funding decisions to local structures and maximise the role of our arts and cultural higher education institutions as centres of excellence.

We will nurture and promote Scotland's young talent by increasing productive links between public support and commercial enterprise. And we will strengthen the link between Scotland's arts and culture and the promotion of tourism and economic growth.

Labour will support national institutions delivering quality and excellence, including a new national theatre for Scotland. But we will also support local authorities and others who are bringing cultural opportunities to our towns, cities and rural communities. And we will support investment in our libraries and museums.

We recognise the importance of Gaelic as a unique part of Scotland's national living heritage. Through Bòrd Gàidhlig na h-Alba we will secure the future of Gaelic by introducing an national language plan and an Action plan to guide the activities of a range of agencies supporting Gaelic. We will

introduce a Bill to provide for the secure status of the Gaelic language. And we will support the Scottish Year of Highland Culture in 2007.

Scotland has many other languages. We will prepare a national language strategy to guide the development and support for all of them, including British Sign Language and ethnic languages. Local language plans will improve the level of support available across Scotland.

Sport is also an integral part of our culture, from great football and athletics triumphs of years gone by to the magnificent achievements of 2002 which saw Scotland's women's curling team win both the Olympic and World Championship titles, a record medal haul at the Commonwealth Games. We want to see a Scotland where everyone has the opportunity to participate in physical activity, bringing enjoyment and contributing to a healthy lifestyle. In our preparations to host the Ryder Cup we will offer all young Scots the chance to learn golf.

We will give anglers the right to fish on watercourses and we will extend the Land Reform Act to ensure that conservation and watercourse management measures are developed.

We will develop six indoor multi-sport facilities across Scotland, including a national indoor arena for competition. These will enable our elite athletes to train in modern conditions all year round, but will also be available for general community use to help broaden the base of those involved in sport. This network will be complemented by two versatile municipal stadia.

We will work with *sportscotland* and local authorities to complete the £87m PE and Sport Programme of new and refurbished sports facilities including swimming pools. That programme will also put resources into imaginative activities such as the Out of School Hours Programme and the Active Steps Programme, which are aimed at getting school children involved in physical activity,

We will work with *sportscotland* to implement the targets in the second stage of our sports strategy and develop our Sports Champions scheme where our successful sportsmen and women inspire and motivate young people to become and remain active in sport.

- **We will consult on the establishment of a single cultural agency for Scotland**
- **We will actively promote our young talent by increasing the productive links between public support and commercial enterprise**
- **We will support a new national theatre for Scotland**
- **We will legislate to provide secure status for the Gaelic language**
- **We will support the development of 6 multi-sport facilities across Scotland, including a national indoor arena of competitive standard**
- **We will work with *sportscotland* to complete the physical education and sport programme of new and refurbished sports facilities, including swimming pools**



# BUILDING A CONFIDENT, DEMOCRATIC SCOTLAND



Scotland is a good place in which to live. As well as improving the quality of life for people living here, we want to make it the home of choice for more of the world's most resourceful and enterprising people. To do this we will celebrate Scotland's diverse culture, create an environment where all of Scotland's people have the opportunity to fulfill their potential, and strengthen our place in the world.

Labour want Scotland to be strong and stable, confident and ambitious. We are not reluctant to tread a different path. For people outside Scotland, our country looks like an attractive destination, a modern European country. To people at home, Scotland is a fulfilling and satisfying place to live.

But if we are to continue to succeed, we must have more ambitions and bigger aspirations as individuals and as a country. Government can't change cultures single-handedly or overnight, but government can act to challenge outdated attitudes that only serve to hold us back.

In a most pressing sense that means acting against racism and sectarianism. Scotland's cultural diversity is a strength that we must nurture and value. We will use the powers of devolution to act against those who peddle racist abuse and perpetrate racist attacks. And we will tackle head on the sectarianism which has blighted our communities for too long.



Religious hatred, violence, prejudice and discrimination are wrong. It fills too many of our people with bitterness and it causes too many too much pain. Sectarianism and racism demean Scotland and Scottish Labour will work to defeat them. Sectarianism and racism demean Scotland and Scottish Labour will work with churches, employers, sporting clubs and schools to defeat them.

A modern, successful country needs a democratic framework that works for people and progress, not one which is too clumsy or out-dated to deliver those public services which matter most to people. Labour will work with others to shape effective partnerships which puts the needs of communities and the country first.

There are some decisions that require to be made in Europe to be most effective. There are others best made at either a UK or Scottish level. We support and we will argue for the principle of subsidiarity so that the right decisions are made at the right level. So we will also support the devolution of power and responsibility inside Scotland, to elected local authorities and beyond. Tenants, community residents, local managers and users of services rightly expect and should have more responsibility and control over areas that more immediately impact on them.

Labour's vision is of a stable devolved Scotland in which everyone has the opportunity to fulfill their potential. A Scotland which is a desirable destination for visitors and business. And where we can, we will not be afraid to lead the world.

## Partnership, Scrutiny and Progress

Over the past four years, Labour has delivered legislation to reflect Scotland's priorities of social justice and excellence in public services. We will continue to ensure that the work of the Parliament matches the priorities of Scottish people.

The first term of the Parliament has also given a voice to Scotland's civic society in a way that was missing during the Tory years. But we have always said the Parliament will need time to earn the respect of the people of Scotland and Labour will continue to work hard to earn that respect.

One of the most important responsibilities that any government has is the responsibility to use the people's money effectively, honestly and with propriety. The resources a government uses are the resources given to it by hard working individual and families. They work to get the best from the

money they have. Like them, any government should be duty bound to make sure that every pound spent is a pound that brings direct benefit and delivers the right result.

Labour in Scotland offers the guarantee that we will be prudent with the Scottish Budget. We will be careful with your money and we will use it wisely. We will always balance the budget. We will invest for the future. We will only fund expenditure that will bring results. We will not use the income tax varying powers we have but will live within the fair share of UK resources that the Barnett formula guarantees for Scotland.

Our Scottish Budget for the next three years provides the resources we need to pay for our plans for Scotland. We have planned wisely and will have the money needed to meet all our commitments.

And we will act to end duplication, buck-passing and waste wherever it exists - whether it is in Scotland's devolved government or in its agencies - and we will act in collaboration with our partners in local government and elsewhere.

Many lessons have been learned from the building of the Parliament's permanent home at Holyrood. We will introduce new regulations for the preparation and management of public works contracts to minimise the potential for large cost overruns and ensure an accountable process.

People in Scotland want decent jobs, to look after their families, to pay their way. Everyone deserves the chance to realise those ambitions and Labour will make sure that all our legislative, policy and resource decisions have equality at their heart. People in Scotland want to live in a country that reaches out to the world, draws strength from its cultural diversity, nurtures its young people and has confidence in its future. Labour represents these ambitions.

- **We will be transparent and accountable in government and we will devolve power inside Scotland**
- **We will be prudent and responsible with the resources we have and invest to deliver results and improvements for Scotland**
- **We will not promise what we can not afford**
- **We will not use the income tax varying power of the Scottish Parliament**

## Local Government, Local Democracy

From the beginning Scottish Labour has worked to make sure that there is strong and effective partnership between the devolved government and local councils. We believe in elected local government and recognise its crucial importance. Labour believes that local services help build communities and the best way to deliver accountable local services is through elected councils.

The next four years are vital to build on that foundation. Labour will continue its focus on the delivery of excellence in public services, with the principles of social and environmental justice underpinning everything we do.

We will encourage local authorities to ensure that community planning works effectively and to find new and innovative ways of involving their local communities. Working with local authorities, we will review the boundaries of the different public organisations that deliver services to

identify ways we can eliminate inefficiencies and reduce barriers to quality by improving their co-operative work.

We will design a fairer council tax banding system which is more representative of house valuations in Scotland today.

Labour strongly supports the direct link between Councillors and those who live in the wards they represent and believes the current electoral system best delivers that accountability.

In order to allow more people to seek election, councillors must be properly supported to perform their role. People who want to pursue a career outside politics should still be able to make a contribution to their local council. We will continue to encourage councils to reform their business practices and structures so that those who wish to be councillors and also have a career can do so.

To widen the pool of people able to stand for local office and to encourage excellence, we will legislate to remove unnecessary political restrictions on those who wish to stand and to change the basis on which councillors are remunerated.

We will establish an Independent Remuneration Committee to advise on remuneration for councillors, taking into account levels of responsibility. And we will lower the age limit for local government candidates to 18.

All healthy democracies require active participation through voting in elections. We have already legislated to allow councils to pilot more modern ways to encourage voting. Some, particularly postal voting, have been successful in raising turnout.

We will modernise the arrangements for voting to increase participation. We will take such powers as are necessary to permit the roll out of new ways of voting across the country.

- **We will design a fairer council tax banding system which is more representative of house valuations in Scotland**
- **We will set up an Independent Remuneration Committee to advise on remuneration for councillors and we will lower the age limit for local government candidates to 18**
- **We will modernise the arrangements for voting to increase participation**

## Scotland in the UK, Europe and the World

Devolution has given Scotland the opportunity to play an active part not only in the UK but in Europe and the world.

Central to our partnership has been our close working relationship with UK Ministers and the Scottish Secretary to ensure that Scotland's distinctive voice is heard when decisions are taken on those areas which are reserved to the UK Government.

Scotland has a long history of trade and interaction with our European neighbours. The development of the European Union has helped to secure greater understanding between countries who have much in common and who share many goals. The single market place has helped to create growing prosperity and we will continue to pursue economic and cultural links across Europe and in particular with the other devolved governments.

In our first four years we have taken steps to make the most of this opportunity. We have established Scotland House in Brussels as our base in Europe and have taken a lead role in the Conference of Regions with Legislative Powers.

We have already made a major input into the new Treaty for Europe being prepared by Giscard d'Estaing through the Convention on the Future of Europe. Once adopted this Treaty will restructure the institutions that govern the European Union and pave the way for enlargement into the east of Europe. We support the enlargement of Europe and will work with the EU Accession States to develop close links between Scotland and the new EU members. We will extend the role of Scotland House, our centre in Brussels, to create the links that will benefit Scotland's business, education and cultural interests.

Scotland has benefited enormously from the resources and strong regional policy promoted by the European Union and as we move forward to an enlarged Europe, we will continue to promote the need for an effective EU regional policy, so that Europe is more relevant to our communities and more in touch with all European citizens.



We will ensure that the Scottish Parliament plays an increasing role in helping to scrutinise European legislation. We will work to represent Scotland in the EU, both directly and through the strength of the UK government. We will continue to champion Scotland's interests in appropriate Council meetings of the EU and inside the UK and will work with Scotland's MEPs to help promote a united voice in the European Parliament.

Scotland has always taken pride in being outward looking. We are internationalist in outlook, not isolationist.

As our Parliament becomes established, we will develop our relations with other nations. We will take the opportunity to use the world-wide interest in Scotland to promote our country, to improve our economic prospects and increase our knowledge and skills.

- **We will use the opportunity of devolution to promote Scotland and stand up for Scotland's interests at home and abroad**
- **We will promote the need for an effective regional policy in Europe**

- **We will ensure that the Scottish Parliament plays an increasing role in scrutinising European legislation**
- **We will work with Scotland's MEPs to promote a united voice in Europe**
- **We will work with the Foreign and Commonwealth Office and the Scotland Office to promote Scottish interests through the UK network of embassies and consulates around the world**
- **We will work with our excellent academic institutions to promote research links, education and student exchanges to raise Scotland's profile and increase opportunity for our young people and build global networks with Scottish institutions at their heart**
- **We will promote Scotland's global sporting, cultural and artistic links and through our Major Events Strategy we will work to bring significant sporting and cultural events to Scotland**

Opportunities come with responsibilities, for governments as well as individuals. And we believe that Scotland has a responsibility to make our contribution to international development.

- **We will engage positively as members of the British-Irish Council**
- **We will build on our participation at the Earth summit held in Johannesburg by working with the UK government to meet our commitments to tackle climate change and promote renewable energy**
- **We will encourage the work of those Scottish NGO's, active in international education programmes, disaster relief and encouraging international development**
- **Labour believes that a modern Scotland in a stronger UK can be a force for good in the world – we will make sure Scotland's voice is heard.**



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